

MARXIST PHILOSOPHY

Keep in Mind: Life is doing, not just thinking. Philosophy must stand on its feet. “Philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however, is to change it.” – (Marx's Thesis to Feuerbach-10)

Intriguing Questions-

- i Whether Marx is actually a philosopher?
- ii. Why Marxist Philosophy is singled out as a course?
- iii. Why are his philosophical ideas so important that they worth studying exclusively?

What do you understand by Marxism/Marxist Philosophy?

Marxism is a philosophical doctrine or a set of philosophical theories especially from economic, social and political spheres developed majorly by Marx with significant contributions from Engels which aims at the extinction of social class differences through the re-arrangement of economic system.

*A Marxist is a strong adherent of Marxism.

Key Concepts in Marxism

- Capitalism
- Working class
- Bourgeoisie
- Proletariat
- Labour
- Surplus-value
- Oppression
- Alienation
- Exploitation
- Socialism
- Communism
- Class struggle
- Dialectics
- Dialectical Materialism
- Historical Materialism
- Materialism
- Economic structure
- Base structure
- Super-structure

- Freedom
- Necessary labour
- Economic relations
- Opium of the people, etc.

Three (3) Main Pillars/Sources of Marxism: Informed by the three main currents as at the time of Marx (19th Century).

- German Philosophy
- Classical English Economy
- French Socialism

Influences on Marxism

- The Personality Marx
- The Relationship between Marx and Hegel, Feuerbach and Engels

- i. The Influence of Hegelian Thoughts on Marx: Idealism and dialectics
- ii. The Influence of Feuerbach on Marxism: Anthropology and Materialism
- iii. The Influence of Engels on Marx: The condition of the working class in England
- iv. French Socialism (cf. *proletariat/Bourgeoisie*): The existence of social problems and the need for new order in the society, fair governance, revolutionary ideas that promote freedom, equality, democracy, etc.

The Influence of Hegelian Thoughts on Marx

The Hegelian thought and philosophy made so much impact on Marx that some of his concepts and notions were borrowed from Hegel's, though sometimes applied differently.

§ Marx shared Hegel's view of overcoming individualism.

§§ Just as Hegel, Marx directed his thoughts towards emancipation and freedom of individuals

§ Hegel's concept of 'Dialectics of Thesis-Anti-thesis and Synthesis' were later seen in Marx's works. Although, in the Historical dialectics of the former, thought precedes matter, while in that of the later, matter precedes thought, in which case, he proudly believes that he has turned Hegel on his feet.

The Influence of Feuerbach on Marxism

As a member of doctor's club in University of Berlin, Marx met Feuerbach around whom they all gathered. Doctor's club is a union of group of students that discuss Hegel's ideas who eventually developed into radical thinkers known as young left-wing Hegelians. Feuerbach was a zealous young Hegelian of the left wing. As an anthropologist, he has a materialistic understanding of man.

He thus conceptualized that man as the product of his environment, whereby his conscience is molded from the interaction between his sensory organs and the external world. Marx had a close collaboration with Feuerbach, later and both criticized Hegel's metaphysical assumptions, though adopted his dialectical ideas on which they eventually based their critiques of the existing *status quo* of their society especially with regard to politics and religion. Marx eventually broke up with Feuerbach when he perceived that the Feuerbach has inconsistent ideas. When Marx later moved to Brussels where he identified himself with other exiled socialists from Europe, he wrote and addressed his two theses to Feuerbach. They were short philosophical notes of critiques of materialism and idealism that Marx believed, placed abstract reality over physical world. They were addressed to Feuerbach and aimed at criticizing his materialistic view of reality as being contemplative thereby reducing praxis to theory. His expression that "Philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however is to change it" was actually addressed to Feuerbach. Marx argued that theory and praxis must harmonize. Life is doing, not just thinking. Philosophy must stand on its feet to 'right the wrongs'. These theses on Feuerbach introduced Marx to his ideas of Historical Materialism, where he established that the world is changed by actual physical and material activity and practice.

One of Marx's notable works is the "**Theses on Feuerbach**," with the 10th thesis being particularly insightful. In this thesis, Marx famously critiqued traditional philosophy for its focus on interpreting the world, arguing that the real goal should be to change it.

His thesis proper: Marx's 10th Thesis to Feuerbach, "*Philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however, is to change it*," encapsulates a critical aspect of his ideology centered around the imperatives of action and change. The statement, while concise, carries profound implications that continue to resonate in various discourses on social change, political reform, and philosophical praxis. At the core of this thesis lies a critique of traditional philosophical approaches, particularly the tendency of philosophers to engage in theoretical contemplation and interpretation without necessarily aiming for practical changes in the material conditions of society. This distinction between mere interpretation and active change underscores Marx's belief in the transformative and revolutionary potential of human agency. Marx's call to move beyond mere interpretation and towards practical action is grounded in his materialist conception of history, which emphasizes the role of economic and social structures in shaping human relationships and experiences. By highlighting the need to change the world, Marx challenges philosophers and individuals alike to not only analyze and understand existing conditions but also to actively work towards transforming them for the better. The 10th Thesis also serves as a rallying cry for those who seek to challenge oppressive systems, advocate for social justice, and bring about radical transformations in society. It serves as a reminder that intellectual inquiry and political activism are intertwined and that true liberation can only be achieved through concrete actions that challenge and destabilize existing power structures.

The Influence of Engels on Marx

Marx academic career was frustrated by the government of the day that opposed classical liberalism and barred young Hegelians of left wing. Marx himself was considered a political threat. As the chief editor, he once wrote, “our newspaper (Neue Rheinische Zeitung) has to be submitted to the police to be sniffled at and if the police nose smells anything un-Christian or un-Prussian, the newspaper is not allowed to appear.” The newspaper which was regularly harassed by police and charged for insulting the government and instigating rebels was later suppressed and he himself was rusticated.

Marx met Engels for the second time in Paris during his exile years. Their meeting at Café spot where they conceived themselves as ‘like radical minds’ earned them a life-long relationship. Engels showed Marx his work ‘on the condition of working class in England (1844) with which he convinced him that the working class could be a practical agent and instrument of their final revolution in history. With Engels, Marx disconnected himself entirely from Feuerbach and the rest of ‘left wing young Hegelians’ whose ideas he believed were too idealistic. He further collaborated with Engels to write ‘German Ideology -*Deutsche Ideologie*) (Marx, K. (1988). *The German Ideology, Literary Theory: An Anthology*. Oxford: Blackwell, 2nd ed. 653-658) popularly known as **MEGA (Marx-Engel Gesamt Ausgabe)**. It is a book written by Marx and Engels with multiple parts of satirical polemics against Bauer, Feuerbach and other young Hegelians and asserting their thoughts on materialistic conception of human history. It was a theoretical framework that contained the major rudimentary ideas of Marx’s materialism, so that Marxism began, while Marx was already in France. The theses to Feuerbach mentioned above was contained in volume V of this collective work of Marx and Engels.

Basis of Marxism

Marxism is based on the conflicting interests between the capitalists (‘the haves’ - property owners) and the proletariats (‘they have nots’ - working class) that gave birth to two major social classes of the bourgeoisie and the proletariats.

Social, economic and political analyses gave rise to the productions of:

- **Das Kapitel** (The Capital) of 1867- Three Volumes- completed by Engels (vols. 2 & 3).
- -Capitalism as the economic practice of the time
- -The Critique of political economy

The Major Ideas in 'The Capital' are:

- The motivating force of capitalism as the oppression of the working class
- The processes of capitalism as alienating, etc.

Another famous work of Marx that interests us most in this discourse is: **Das Manifest der Kommunistischen Partei- Communist Manifesto (Manifesto of Communist Party)**

Pls read and digest the lines of this work for our subsequent discussions on Marxism.

March 7

Now, briefly drop here what you understand by:

1. Capitalism
2. Alienation
3. Necessary labour
4. Surplus Value
5. Dialectics

Now, a quick quiz:

- What are the major influences on Marx?
- What is the basis of Marxism?
- What is (are) the central message(s) of Communist Manifesto?

The core messages of Communist Manifesto are:

- The obvious existence of two hostile camps (the bourgeoisie and the proletariats) that implicates class struggle due to their constant oppositions.
- Capitalism as containing the seed of its destruction.
- The Importance and the inevitability of revolution Hence, the **motto of Manifesto is a Battle Cry**, admonishing the proletariats to join forces for their common interest. Thus, *Proleterier aller Länder, vereinigt Euch!* - Working men of all countries, Unite!

With the understanding that

“Philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however is to change it.

The Goals of Marxism are:

- To abolish the economic system that favors social problems
- To establish justice in the society through realization of classless society in favor of more rational, active and independent citizens
- To abolish ownership of private properties and all rights regarding property inheritance in order to centralize property and labour.
- To replace capitalism with socialism and then finally with communism in order to overcome alienation so that man actualizes his essence in true freedom and creativity.
- To ensure equal living conditions of efficient distribution of human resources in the society (to each according to his need)
- To maintain more stable economic system and absence of unhealthy competition (from each according to his ability).
- To free laborers from the alienation of capitalism in favor of necessary labour

- To promote the dignity of labour
- The proposition that the class struggle will definitely lead to communism for true and fulfilling labour conditions

This was based on the Assumptions that:

- Capitalism was the economic practice of the time that by implication necessitates the subjugation of the working class.
- There became obvious social classes brought about by economic system that favors inequality
- There exists therefore master-slave, oppressor-oppressed relationships in the society.
- The capitalists increase their values through exchange of labour-power for meagre wages that made the working class never happy
- Hence, the two classes are in constant opposition
- More industries concentrate more laborers and became fertile opportunity for revolts
- Human history develops due to social changes of the class struggles. Hence, the conviction of the material force of human development

The rest of the discussions on Marxism will border on the following:

- Marx and Historical Materialism
- v The Marxian Dialectical Materialism
- v Marx and the State Freedom and Necessity in Marx
- v Marx's proposed Ideal State: Reality or Utopia?

Marxism and the Contemporary Period

- v Is Karl Marx still relevant in our time?
- v How useful are his ideas today?

Historical Materialism points at two poles:

History and Material world·

- History, because it considers changes over time·
- Material, because it concerns material reality

The historical materialism of Marx is a philosophy of history that endorses materialistic understanding of history. It is also an approach of the theory of economics based on materialistic view of reality; an economic interpretation of history. Marx's *Theses on Feuerbach* and his work on *German Ideology* form the bases of his theoretical account on human society; the different structures of human society and their evolutionary progressions in reactions to chains of conflicts between the classes. His idea of historical materialism was adopted from Hegelian dialectic view of history as is so evidenced in his dialectical materialism. However, Marx rejected Hegel's idealistic notion that the spirits the driving force of history and argued for the primacy of matter over thoughts; hence historical materialism (materialism as the only force of history). He engaged the rest of his life in an insightful survey of political economy that yielded 3-Volumes of materialistic analysis of human history (*das Kapital*), while in between editing radical newspapers, organizing and directing political parties for uprising of citizenry for revolution.

In his masterpiece of economic theory (*Das Kapital*), Marx explicates his notion of the economic laws of motion of modern society. In his view, man cannot eat ideas. He must eat before he thinks. Based on this, he firmly reiterates that matter precedes thought as against Hegel. Therefore, economic factors condition people's life and thought; the basis for human history. Using socio-economic laws, he identifies three key elements of economic history of human society. Thus;

- **§ Forces (Means) of Production:** Any means (Technology or human power) that can be used for production.
- **§ Relations of Production:** Practices that govern productions in relation to forces of production and superstructure (human, property and technical relations of production, employer-employee work conditions, divisions of labour, etc.)).
- **§ Causal Power of ideas** (Institutions, culture, legal system, political system, philosophy, Church, etc.) = SUPERSTRUCTURE

Marx identified that although the superstructure impacts on the substructure, the later exerts greater influence on the former which gives rise to conflictual relationships and automatic historical motion.

Hence, mode of production is the base of economic evolutions. Hence, historical materialism in Marxian context is understood as the force of material world that drives human development. This is chiefly seen in the economic production of good for sustenance of human needs.

This is the major assumption of Marx that propelled him to assert that:

- Man is a material being with material needs such as water, food, shelter, etc.
- He delineates:

“We must begin by stating the first premise of all human existence and therefore of all history; the premise that men must be in a position to live in order to be able to make history. But life involves before everything else eating and drinking, a habitation, clothing and many other things. The first historical act is thus the production of the means to satisfy these needs, the production of material life itself. And indeed, this is a historical act, a fundamental condition of all history, which today as thousands of years ago, must daily and hourly be fulfilled merely in order to sustain human life.” (cf. Marx, *das Kapitel*).

Man sustains himself by satisfying these material needs- the primacy of matter over reason. Marx rejected Hegel’s idealistic notion that the spirit is the driving force of history and argued for the primacy of matter over thoughts, hence historical materialism.

- The nature of sustenance determines man’s relationship to the means of production
- This relationship to the means of production explains the class of the individual (own land, other properties etc. or offer labour in exchange of wage- the ‘haves and the have nots’)

With the Capitalist nature of his time, Marx identified two classes of people:

- Capitalists (Bourgeoisie)- Profit minded
- Laborers (proletarians)- wage minded

The two classes of people have two different interests, namely;

- To work as hard as possible to increase capital value
- To get as much paid as possible for the labour done.

*These two interests are in diametrical opposition with each other which no policy can claim to resolve. The resultant effect is conflict= conflict of the two classes (conflict of classes).

* The interest of one group constrains that of another.

Hence, historical development is a matter of class struggle.

At the very beginning of the Manifesto, he wrote: “The beginning of all hitherto existing society, is the history of all class struggles.”- Freeman and slave, etc.

Class and Class Conflict

‘Class’ here refers to a class (group) of people who have common features with regard to socioeconomic status (living conditions). Classes of people are defined by their places in relation to production (economic status). ·

- The bourgeoisie own and control the means of production and employ wage-labour. ·
- The proletarians sell their labour power in order to sustain life for lack of ownership power.

Marxian theory of conflict explains ways of struggling of the groups of people over power for control of resources (class struggle). Class conflict is often as a result of material needs.

The group that has the power already strives to maintain it and keep the other in a constant powerless state. The other submits themselves to the exploitation of the powerful group for lack of no better option at the moment until they accumulate enough force to gain over power through coercion.

*Class conflict theory is based on ‘labour relations.

March 21

CAPITALISM and issues around it.

What actually do you understand by capitalism?

Capitalism is a form of labour organization that permits private ownership of the means of production whereby the value of the product is measured by the amount of labour spent for the production under normal circumstances.

Now, what are the benefits and detriments of capitalism? at least two each

Capitalism is Marx’s Philosophical Framework With his evaluation of the state of Capitalism of his time, he identified that:

- Labour is a great source of value
- It is measured in time (time is money)- cf Marx’s labour theory of value.
- Labour power- i.e. the ability to labour that increases the value of production and it is found mainly in people.

As such, capitalism exploits labour in exchange of less wage. This lesser pay becomes the difference (gain- surplus) between labour and payment. *Here lies the exploitative nature of Capitalism to which Marx points.

Capitalism leads to massive inequality and as the capitalists always strive for expansion of coast of surplus value, the proletariats struggle for change in force of production. To this Marx observed that ‘capitalism contains the seed of its destruction.’

Why:

- The capitalists compete among themselves.
- Acquire more wage laborers (who in turn form more force for eventual struggle) for more explosive economic growth. ·
- The maximization of profit which implicates reduction of wages will eventually cause economic crisis due to lack of cooperation among the two classes for divergent interests. ·
- That is to say, the same relations of production that created economic growth will eventually cause crisis (over production-surplus value again lesser and lesser wages) due to contradiction between the forces and relations of production. ·
- Labour-surplus value- less wage-exploitation- conflict- struggle for power overcontrol of production.

Marx clearly stated that capitalism has the following consequences:

- Class strata
- Exploitation for Surplus value
- Class Struggle
- New stage of development, etc.

Marx purports that freedom of people lies in CHANGING the status quo- that is, the ELIMINATION OF CAPITALISM (clearly a TOOL FOR EXPLOITATION AND CLASS STRUGGLE) and CENTRALIZATION OF MEANS OF PRODUCTION for equal access (from each according to his ability and to each according to his needs), to form a classless society (communism). Hence, his assertion that material conditions shape human development.

so, Marx laid much emphasis on changing the state of affairs of his time- capitalism. According to him, “the philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however is to change it.” He desires to create a more humane human society that is devoid of exploitation domination and oppression.

How?

To form a classless society where all people have equal relationship to the means of production (communism in view).

This assumption of Marx ushers us into the discussion on Dialectical Materialism.

As we engage in it, pls note that:

In Marxian understanding, history is not a collection of dead facts or imagined activities of people but the interaction between substructure (forces and relations of production) and superstructure. Based on this notion, materialism is considered as the only force of history. Therefore, development of history revolves around the economic changes of the society. Constant historical development is the reflections of changes in economic and material relations of economic structures. At the change of the basic economic structure, the revolution class becomes the ruling class that forms the superstructure and harbors governing ideology of the given historical period. By ideology, Marx meant the interest of a particular class of a peculiar time in history accepted by the contemporaries as universal and eternal. The ruling class is the material force of the society which regulates production and distributes ideas of the given time. As the ruling class changes, ideas of the society change too. The cause of change of ruling class is revolution to impact the desired change

The Marxian Dialectical Materialism

Dialectics explained: Dialectics is a process of discovery through opposing realities. It is simply a method of getting at truth through removal of contradictory elements. It is a systematic reasoning that usually involves contradictory ideas (interactions, relations, transformations, etc.) which produce a new situation as it seeks to resolve their conflicts.

Marxian application of dialectics was highly influenced by Hegel's which is comprised of triadic development of **Thesis, Anti-thesis and Synthesis** (which in turn forms a new thesis).

- The **Thesis** serves as the initial position when everything seems stable
- The **Anti-thesis** is when the situation is questioned and faced with contradictions (anti-thetical consciousness) which necessitates a change. It is the Irreconcilable struggles that melt into a synthesis.
- The **Synthesis** is the third situation when the contradictory moments are resolved, then a new situation is formed which eventually develops into a **new unity** (thesis) and the cycle continues.

*For Hegel, with his background of process theology, dialectics is an enquiry into how the world operates that aids the interpretation of human history and it is based on Divine consciousness. Hence, the final synthesis is God when at the end of the history all will be made complete (cf. Phenomenology of the spirit).

For Marx, the ultimate and solution to the contradictory processes is communism.

* While Hegel proposes **Idealistic Materialism**, Marx diverts to **Dialectical Materialism** with the conviction that material world drives human development.

* While Hegel maintained that history is moved by reason (consciousness) and as such held to the primacy of reason over matter, Marx delineates the fact that historical events are consequences of social conflicts and contradictions caused by material needs thereby placing material conditions over idealism.

The Marxian dialectical process is governed by three laws, namely;

1. Law of Unity and conflict of opposites: Here, the process involves mutually opposing elements in conflict.
2. Law of Negation: When the means of production is negated by its internal contradiction.
3. Law of transition of quantity into quality: Here, accumulation of wealth transits to qualitative change (the birth of a new order)- From slavery to freedom.

Using the socio-economic analysis of class relations and social conflicts, Marx analyzed social and economic activities from the perspective of materialistic interpretation of historical development based largely on the influences of Hegel's dialectics, Feuerbach's anthropological materialism and the conditions of working class in England.

the developmental stages of human history as influenced by dialectical materialism of Marx.

25 March

DIALECTIC MATERIALISM OF MARX

Pls note the major difference between Historical Materialism and Dialectical Materialism. DO NOT MIX THEM UP UNNECESSARILY especially during exam.

though both of them are so interwoven, but:

Historical materialism is an economic interpretation of history with an approach of the theory of economics based on materialistic view of reality. It is based on the theoretical account of human society based on economic factors that condition people's life and thought whereby Marx identifies

three key elements of economic history of human society, namely; the Forces of production, the Relations of Production and the Causal Power of Ideas.

While in **Dialectic Materialism**, Marx uses socio-economic relations and social conflicts to analyze and interpret how the development of human history is being influenced in various stages of human existence.

Marx's dialectical Materialism cleaves to the idea that human history evolves due to class conflicts of opposing forces (dialectics) and it evaluates five historical stages of Economic development and social relations of the classes.

The analysis of the historical processes is based on the structural mode of production (the means and social relations of production).

In Marxian understanding, every one belongs to a class in history. Classes are determined by economic structure made up of force and relations of productions. Each means of production generates its opposition that result in conflict of the two classes. The mode of production changes constantly as the two forces (of the means of production and the relations of production) are continuously in struggle. Each conflicting situation generates a new relationship, that is, a change in class arrangement. Subsequently, each new stage emerges through dialectical courses of actions of Thesis, Anti-thesis and Synthesis, whereby the synthesis in turn forms a new thesis. Hence, all changes take place through conflicts of opposing forces; the classes.

Marx recognizes five outstanding stages of human development in history.

1. The first ever stage is the Primitive stage. §

Primitive Communism: Is also known as **Tribal Society**. It began after the dawn of humanity. Citizens live in community and own no private properties. Hunting and farming were major occupations and the proceeds are shared among all according to sizes and needs. All were inevitably involved in production; each according to his ability and they worked mainly to satisfy the instantaneous needs. The stage transforms into a new structure with the development of large-scale agricultural practices and gradual acquisition of private properties that were not meant for immediate consumptions.

2. The second stage is the period of Slavery. §

Slave Society: At this stage, primitive technology lethargically gives way to more modern technologies and consequently to a large-scale agricultural system. The exclusive possession of goods and assets becomes more obvious in which case the acquisition of lands and slaves happen to be the major sources of economy and affluence. The slaves were exploited and were made to work without any payment. They demonstrated reluctance for the use of new technologies. As they desired to be free, the need to keep and maintain more slaves posed great challenges and irreconcilable contradictions of the classes that resulted in revolution, destroyed the old relationship and created a new one. Eventually, the game put the classes in great crises. So, a new

situation emerged. Actually, Marx is of the view that what we refer to as 'state' today originated in this very stage.

3. The 3rd period is the Feudal stage. §

Feudal Stage (Feudalism): This period gave birth to many Kings and Lords with large possession of private properties. The need to protect the properties made them enter into security contract with the peasants and the serfs for a peanut remuneration. But along the line, the later groups desired too to have their own assets which automatically brings them into irresistible conflicts with their masters as the mode of production effectively changes. Consequent upon these, a novel society emerged.

4. The 4th Stage is the period into which he was born. §

Capitalism: This form of society acknowledged that the means of labor fell into the hands of a limited few; the property owners (the bourgeoisie), while the servitudes; the propertyless class (the proletariats) exchange their labors for commodities and their properties become the profit of their masters. Worse still, they were so exploited for surplus value against meagre reward. Their excess labour gave rise to more profits and new technologies. This practice existed during the era of Marx. In fact, he fell a victim and he was so opportuned to carry out direct studies of industrial reports together with his friend Engel. This existential concern made him to vehemently oppose the system and he urgently calls for emancipation, a radical reorganization of the economic structure to a classless state of modern communism that will begin with socialism and eventually culminate into pure communism for the common good of all. From his findings, he established that capitalism alienates and exploits workers.

*Marx always meant that "Capitalism contained the seed of its destruction." So, a new situation must emerge.

5. The 5th which he considered the very last stage is his proposed Ideal Stage. §

Modern Communism: Marx reiterates that "the philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however is to change it." He then proposed a modern Communism for a meaningful and fulfilled labour that promotes human freedom, worth and dignity. The new society will commence with the first phase of Socialism and culminates into the second phase; the communism. It will satisfy the necessity of human labor, while it upholds optimal human freedom.

This last stage was proposed based on Marx's evaluation of capitalism as majorly a dehumanizing period.

In our next meeting, we will focus on the consequences of Capitalism that led to the proposal of the 5th stage. Meanwhile, make out a good time to study in details these stages. Then as your assignment, find out and state clearly:

1. The **THESIS** of each stage of human development
2. The **ANTI-THESIS** of each stage, as well as
3. The **SYNTHESIS** of each stage

*To be submitted as soon as I come for physical lecture on which you will be well notified

28 March

The CONSEQUENCES OF CAPITALISM and implicitly influenced by DIALECTIC MATERIALISM.

We already acknowledged that in Capitalism, the property owners (the bourgeoisie) depend on the servitudes; the propertyless class (the proletariats) whereby the later exchange their labors production of commodities which become the profit of their masters. Worse still, they were so exploited for surplus value against meagre reward.

This was the framework of Marxist theory and Critique of Capitalism.

Before we proceed with the negative effects of Capitalism, let us quickly admit that although capitalism harbors a lot of dehumanizing practices, it is not totally evil. It has a few positive impacts on human development such as:

- Industrial boom especially in Europe
- Technological advancement- High productive force
- Widening of the global trade

The Consequences of Capitalism

- § Subjection of the Proletariats to servitudinal labour conditions by the Bourgeoisie
- § Rendering of forcible services by the low-class citizens for survival
- Automatic emergence of inequality
- § Obvious conflicts between the citizens as there gradually arose clashes of irreconcilable interests
- § Forcible coercions (creation of forces)- This is what Marx meant by an organized economic domination of the economic powerful class to exploit the rest.
- § Terms of services (economic relations) were defined
- § Even factions begin to exist among the dominating class as the strong ones try to swallow the weaker ones. And so on.

However, the most accentuated consequence in the light of Marxism is **HUMAN ALIENATION**. Hence, we will give it particular attention now.

What do you understand by alienation?

Marx considers **ALIENATION** as a very dehumanizing experience and in Fact, **A TRAGEDY OF HUMAN LIFE**.

Why? Because, In Marxian teaching, alienation has to do with estrangement (*entfremdung*) of workers from necessary aspects of their human species (species-essence) due to division of labour and class.

THE TRAGEDY OF HUMAN ALIENATION

Two major features of alienation in Marxist Theory are **social isolation** and **powerlessness**.

This idea buttresses the fact that workers are objectified as instruments (tools for another purpose) and denied of their autonomy (deprivation of self-determination).

In Marxism, autonomy which enables self-assertion in existence is a very significant concept for self-actualization.

Self-actualization in turn is self-affirmation brought about by man's creative nature but which can only be realized in freedom. Hence, Marx's notion of Freedom and Necessity. We shall commit to that in due time.

Marx identified about four kinds of Alienation, namely;

1. **Alienation from Product-** This form of alienation objectifies the worker to feel foreign to the works of his own hand by his not being able to see or possess the products of his labour. In other words, Workers are being distanced from the products of their labours. "Man's own deed becomes an alien power opposed to him which enslaves him instead of being controlled by him." Workers are free sellers of labour power who carry themselves as commodity to wherever they find market...these newly freed men (freed from feudalism) became sellers of themselves only after they had been robbed of all their own means of production and of all the old feudal arrangements...The history of this is written in the annals of mankind in letters of blood and fire." (*Das Kapital, Primitive accumulation- Part VIII*). As such, they are highly degraded to the worst (miserable, so cheap) form of commodity.

2. **Work Process Alienation**-This kind of alienation makes the worker helpless as he lacks control over his labour power. Workers are also separated from the activities of production. Workers are being dehumanized; being identified with work/belt numbers instead of their names. Workers are being reduced beasts of burdens.

3. **Social Alienation**- This form of alienation deprives the worker his social life due to excess time committed to labour. “Eating, drinking, procreating, etc. are indeed truly human functions. But in the abstraction that separates them from the other round of human activity and makes them into final and exclusive ends they become animal...his personal life (for what is life except activity) as an activity directed against himself, independent of him and not belonging to him. It is self-alienation, as above it was the alienation of the object.”- (Karl Marx, *Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts Selected Writings*, ed. David McLellan, Oxford University Press, 1978, 77.
 “The Palaces are being produced for the riches, while hovels are being built for the workers. Hence, Marx advocated for economic necessary labour that will avail the individual great opportunity to develop themselves and actualize their other potentials of various dimensions of life.

4. The last of the four major forms of alienation as identified by Marx is: **Alienation from specie-being**- Here, the worker is estranged from so many human attributes by putting him directly against his fellow men in the scenario of competition in the labour field. In other words, workers are as well isolated from their true selves. Workers are further set against one another physically and psychologically and they consider themselves as competitors for the jobs they do (estrangement of man from man).

Pls note these ALIENATIONS in their forms and characteristics

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4th April

How many forms of alienation are noted by Marxism?

THE STATE.

At what point of the development of the human history did the State emerge, in Marxian theory?

Recalling Marx's position that at the basis of each action is an economic motive, we then reason that Marxian state it was influenced by material conditions (economic conditions). He pointed out clearly that the state originated at the **slavery period**, where the possession of private properties automatically gave rise to two classes of citizens (property owners and propertyless citizens). Eventually, this led to the feeling of insecurity and concern for protection and so on.

The state is one of the elements of superstructure (causal power of ideas, rationalization, etc.).

Hence, the State therefore has the fundamental purposes of:

- § Rendering of forcible services by the low-class citizens.
- § Providing security for property owners
- § Paying of taxes

Call to mind again that material possession which fueled the origin of state has many adverse effects, namely;

- § Automatic appearance of inequality
- § Obvious conflicts between the citizens as there gradually arose clashes of irreconcilable interests.
- § Forcible coercions (creation of forces)- This is what Marx meant by an organized economic domination of the economic powerful class to exploit the rest.
- § The property owners wanted to subject the others to servitudinal security labour at a meagre sum.
- § Terms of services (economic relations) were defined
- § Even factions begin to exist among the dominating class as the strong ones try to swallow the weaker ones.

Marx's Analysis of the State:

In his eminent twenty-three-page Pamphlet, (*Communist Manifesto*, 24th Feb. 1848) which harbors the critique of political economy, he presented his idea of the state as:

§ A political organization led by the economic dominant class

§ The executive committee of the bourgeoisie for managing their common affairs

§ An instrument of exploitation

§ The inhuman system that treats the disadvantaged as mechanical monads

Keeping to his conception of the state and following his view that the state is machinery for oppression, Marx opted for a classless, stateless society of full democracy and optimal communism.

Hmmm! A utopic project...

Marx's Conception of Ideal State- A Just Society for All (From Dystopia to Utopia)

Dystopia- the dehumanizing society

Utopia- An ideal state that is desired may not be attained because human beings are imperfect beings.

The central idea of Marx's ideal state is emancipation (freedom from the alienated economic-abundance and exploited work style) of laborers and invariably of all. So, he meant that the freedom and development of the individuals are invariably that of all. Hence, the driving force for the change is the 'freedom' of the proletariats from all manner of dehumanization. Freedom is a very important concept in Marxism as true human development occurs in freedom.

WAY FORWARD TOWARDS ACTUALIZATION OF IDEAL STATE

Necessity of Revolution- Consequence of Capitalism The very beginning of the Manifesto and the very end of it expressed this spirit of revolution clearly. Thus, "A spectre is haunting Europe-the spectra of communism. All the Powers of old Europe have entered into a holy alliance to exorcise this scepter: Pope and Czar, Metternich and Guizot, French radicals and German police-spies... let the ruling classes tremble at a communistic revolution. The proletarians have nothing to lose but their chains. They have a whole world to win. WORKING MEN OF ALL COUNTRIES, UNITE!" (Karl Marx and Frederick Engels: selected Works, International Publishers, NY, 1968, Vol. I, Communist Manifesto, 35 & 63.)

To effect historical changes of his time, revolution was considered a good option. Marx therefore persuaded the working class (proletariats) that it is acting in their own best interest to overthrow the capitalist society (bourgeoisie) and replace it with socialism. To be allowed to pass through government censor, he made it a pseudonymous article titled "Poverty of Philosophy". He maintained a communist league and workers' club with socialist groups from various European countries through which he disseminated information. The conscientization of citizens on their working conditions led to series of protests, rebellions, violent and upheavals in Europe. The revolution of 1948 that came after the publication of the "*manifesto of the communist party*", was attributed to Marx who also was accused of financial aid to Belgian workers through the inheritance of his father's and uncle's properties.

In chapter 7 of the Capital, Marx delineates that human beings possess dual selves; the actual and the potential selves. The development of self begins with the expression of internal alienation. Human alienation is giving up of one's labour, whereby products appear to have life and movement to which human beings merely adapt. According to him, human nature involves transformation that requires economic freedom and necessity, that is, "from each according to his ability and to each according to his need."

Having studied and analyzed the reports and data of the state of affairs and conditions of mode of work especially of his time (Capitalist period), Marx opted for radical changes and creation of a new society that will serve the benefit of all. This is what he refers to as putting philosophy on its feet; harmonization of theory and praxis. Although he pointed out number conditions that are basic to his vision, he did not give a large scale of concrete scheme that shapes his idea of Communism. One will immediately assume that it is purposeful since he is convinced that values arise out of condition of a particular time and solutions that will improve the conditions of the time will equally emerge from the given period.

However, he proposed the following in favors of pure Communism:

- a. Eradication of private properties and individual rights thereby eliminating class systems and struggles among citizens.
- b. Division of labour which was considered one of the evils of modern life that cogs laborers to machines and alienates them from the products of their labours must be gotten rid of.
- c. Abolition of surplus labour of the masses and non-labour of a few. This will automatically overcome alienation and melt down the exchange value.
- d. To introduce the necessary labour time that upholds human worth and dignity so that the citizens will engage themselves in free activities that develop them and avail them fulfilment.
- e. The development of individual in free creative activities builds scientific minds set free in time and means created for all to transform the world for fuller realization of humanity.
- f. Recognition of individuals in powerful technologies, while preserving nature for future generations and maintaining social relationships.
- g. Bringing productive activities under control and regulating labour in favor of human conditions that uplift human dignity.
- h. Citizens become ultimately free

Pls note well:

Socialism is a Transitory State

Socialism is a transition stage for reformation, recovery and preparation for communism

11 April

Having dealt with Marx's proposed ideal state, we turn to the conditions that will enable it

We mentioned those conditions but i wish to recap the last discussion by highlighting them again.
Thus:-

- To abolish ownership of private properties and all rights regarding property inheritance in order to centralize property and labour.-
- To replace capitalism with socialism and then finally with communism in order to overcome alienation so that man actualizes his essence in true freedom and creativity.-
- To ensure equal living conditions of efficient distribution of human resources in the society (to each according to his need)- To maintain more stable economic system and absence of unhealthy competition (from each according to his ability).-

- To free laborers from the alienation of capitalism in favor of necessary labour that promote true and fulfilling labour conditions- To promote the dignity of labour-
- The proposition that the class struggle will definitely lead to communism for true and fulfilling labour conditions-
- To abolish the economic system that favors social problems and-
- To establish justice in the society through realization of classless society in favor of more rational, active and independent citizens.

Now, if you have gone through the points consciously, you notice that labour is at the center of the purported problem of capitalism and actualization of ideal proposed state.

However, the understanding of labour takes two extreme dimensions in the two cases:

1. Excess labour
2. Necessary labour

Our concern today is on necessary labour that implies ultimate freedom

Freedom and Necessity in Marx

The free development of each is the condition for the free development of all.” (*Communist Manifesto*, p. 53)

Pls have the above dictum in mind as we advance.

What then are Freedom and Necessity in the light of Marxism?

Fundamentally, Marx conceives and strongly nurtures the idea that economic necessary work can at the same time be fulfilling and free.

Marx elucidates his notion of Freedom and Necessity in his Magnum Opus (*das Kapital*, vol. 3) where he establishes that freedom is the recognition of necessity.

With his explication of freedom and necessity, one immediately notes that he bears two forms of state in mind (two economic modes), namely; the Capitalism of his time and the Communalism that he proposes to come. In the former, he emphasizes and criticizes the over-bearing of the exchange-value motif and charts its adverse effects on the low class citizens, while in the later, he projects the use-value motif of communism, whereby he expresses the necessity of human labour as fulfilling and free development of the individuals who define themselves as active creative creatures that interacts with nature and fellow beings under humane natural conditions that promote the worth and integrity of man.

FREEDOM

With Marx, freedom has to do with the removal of obstacles to human emancipation which avails the producers the opportunity to rationally regulate their labours and their relationships with both nature and fellow beings. In this sense, freedom is not merely an absence of constraints but a positive feature in directing the rational person to self-determination (cf. das Kapitel).

NECESSITY

With necessity, Marx refers to economically necessary labour that man must engage in to produce and satisfy his material needs. Interpreting Marx, Cohen refers to it as regrettable, gloomy pessimistic necessity of labour, while Berke terms it somber and realistic necessity of labour. However, Marx admonishes that knowing and applying correctly the law of nature to meet up with basic human needs is of paramount importance.

Many philosophers uphold the traditional view that man is basically a rational being and that human life peculiar to man is that of reason such that labour is a lower activity to man. Therefore, his material nature is an animal characteristic of him. Also in the biblical literature, work is attributed to man's fallen nature as a punishment, a curse, toil, etc. (cf. the fall of Adam and Eve). Although, the social teachings of the Church have made man find meaning and fulfilment in the works he does; the dignity of man's labour.

Pls take a little time to digest this excerpt:

“Labour is the essence of man and the basis of society. Man is a laboring animal. It is just in his work upon the objective world...that man proves himself to be a species being. This production is his species life. Through this production, nature appears as his work and his reality”. CW iii 277 (Marx and Engels, Collected Works, 50 Vols published or in preparation (London, 1975)).

“The animal is immediately one with its life activity. It does not distinguish itself from it. It is its life activity. Man makes his life activity itself the object of his will and his consciousness. He has his conscious life activity...conscious life activity distinguishes man immediately from animal life activity.

- ” CWiii 276.

“Like the other animals, man is part of nature, and, like them, he is motivated by the need to survive, and to reproduce himself. But what sets human beings apart from other animals is the wide variety of ways in which human beings can meet their needs. This is possible because human beings are conscious and self-conscious creatures.” – Callinicos, Alex (2010). *The Revolutionary Ideas of Marx*. Lagos: Books farm House and Publishers.

However, based on the above, man is essentially considered as majorly a consumer other than a producer who merely works to satisfy his physiological needs; the necessity of labour. In the light of inevitability of labour, Marx asserts that work has a peculiar place in man's life. Hence, man is

essentially an active creative creature who develops and fulfils himself mainly through productive activities. As such, work becomes for him a 'Vital Activity', an essential activity, a specie of man, a free activity and a 'Life's Prime Want' (cf. Marx and Engel, Selected Works).

Pls read consciously:

As Hegel opines that human history is a progress of humanity towards true freedom expressed in self-understanding and mastery, so Marx meant that work which is a crucial facet of human history is meant to satisfy the material needs of man but it is meant to be a free activity that aids him to objectify and realize himself and not be simply consumed by it. According, to Marx, Self-objectification and self-realization have their hallmark (fullest development) in free creative activity of Arts. Art is understood as the highest form of work for the reasons that the objects are not simply consumed, rather they are transformed and preserved. In this manner, the desire for them is transcended. This is what he meant by 'activity in the realm of freedom' (cf. das Kapitel, Vol.3). Consequently, artistic creation as work is aestheticized. Considering this idea, it becomes obvious that Marx borrowed it from Hegel (though used it in a slightly different way) who establishes that work is a practical being-for self whereby gratification from immediate desire and appetite is deferred as the object is not immediately consumed but it is transformed and altered in which case man creates a distinct human relationship with the nature; separated from, though remains part of it. This is what Hegel considers as self-objectification and self-consciousness, humanization of labour to feel at home with it and be part of his creative activity. In Marxian term, it is so known as overcoming of division and alienation from nature, labour and creative activity of man. Both Hegel and Marx uphold that work plays a vital role in human life as it animates man, makes him conscious of himself and his environment and distinguishes him from animals who are merely driven by desire and instincts and have purely immediate role to nature, self and environment. So, man's true freedom lies in his conscious activities.

With Necessity and Freedom

Marx observes that man's conflicts of free time and labour are antagonizing human conditions that must be overcome as man's happiness lies in striking a healthy balance between them and not to place one over the other. He counsels that the true realm of freedom blossoms with realm of necessity at its base. This is freedom in appreciation of necessity.

Marx reiterates that to reconcile the antagonism between Labour and freedom, surplus value accruing from excess labour hours must be minimized, while free time that allows man some sort of self-development be maximized (contraction of time devoted to necessary labour to create time for free activity). By this, he meant the observation of normal length of time for labour such that the brute physical exertion brought about by technology should be minimized through the rational application and regulation of it. In this sense, labour must be done strictly under conditions most favorable to human nature, worth and dignity at the least expenditure of energy.

So, he stated:

It is self-evident that if labour is reduced to a normal length and furthermore labour is no longer performed for someone else but for myself and at the same time the social contradictions between master and servant being abolished, it requires a quite different, a free character. (*Theories of Surplus Value*, 1972, 257)

Simply put: Marx opines that economic value be transvalued from surplus-value to use-value in order to contract labour hours and maximize free hours for self-actualization through creative activities.

Hence, man is considered by Marx as a CREATIVE BEING.

Marx is so much interested in development of citizens through creative labours. In this case, he meant that labour should be aestheticized for true human freedom.

Considering all these, Marx's PREDICTION OF PREREVOLUTION still persists.

The revolution which did eventually occur in Europe was attributed to Marx. That saw to his exile from France in 1849. However, the high rate of industrial growth many years after the revolution was seen as a result of the good treatments of the workers that benefited all and severe wealth inequality became a past issue.

Now,

How useful are his ideas today?

Is he still relevant in our time and society?

Does our today's Nigeria have need for application of Marxian theories?